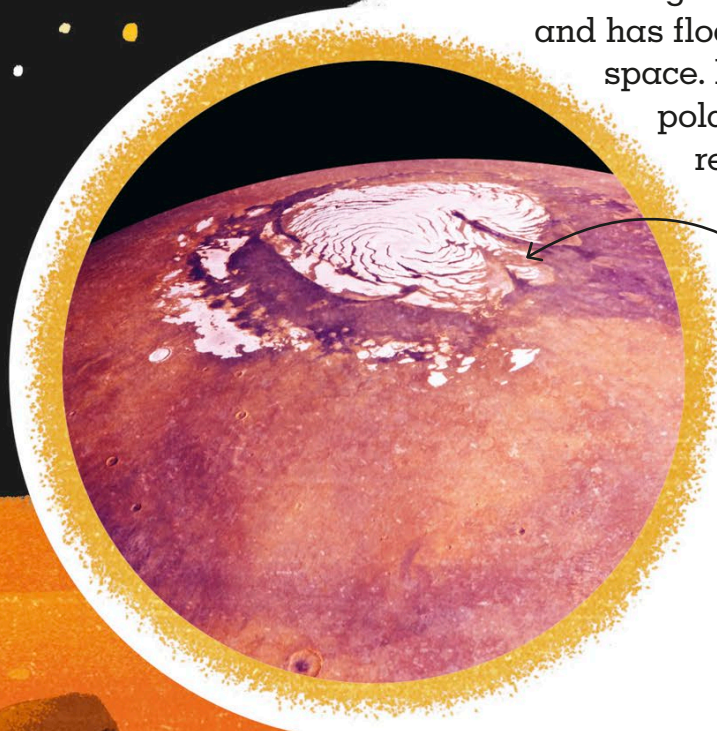


The atmosphere

The layer of gas around a planet is called its atmosphere. Mars's thin atmosphere doesn't filter out harmful radiation from the Sun, such as solar wind (particles that can damage anything they touch).

Water on Mars

Mars's water has mostly been heated into a gas by the Sun, and has floated off into space. However, polar ice caps remain.



The ice caps get so cold that gas freezes solid and falls from the air.

Investigating Mars

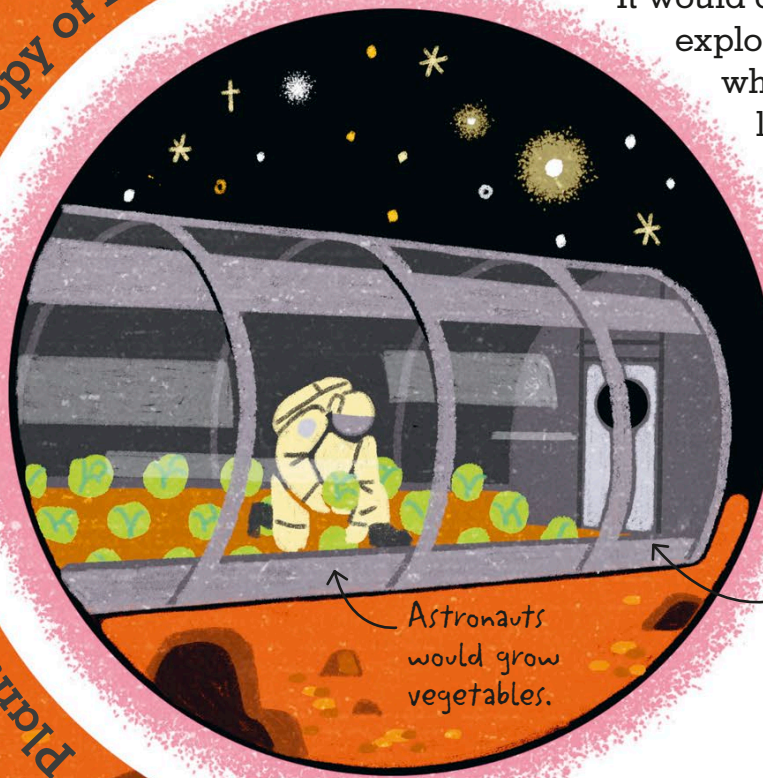
In 2020, The European Space Agency plans to send a rover to Mars. Its mission is to search for alien life that could be buried in the soil.

Astro-gardeners

To grow plants on Mars, a special greenhouse would be needed to protect the plants from the extreme temperatures.

It would also stop them exploding in the air, which has very low pressure.

Plants have been grown in a copy of Martian soil.



Astronauts would grow vegetables.

A special greenhouse could add air pressure.